gress is taking the BJP to task over the rape allegations against Hassan MP Prajwal Revanna.

The She Revolution

What explains the new gender awakening that is influencing Indian election results and making political parties pursue the female constituency? Women in India have held the franchise since Independence, when the country opted for universal suffrage (the first general election was held in 1951-52). But it is arguably only in the past decade or so that they have really grasped the efficacy of their vote. Sukanya Ganguly, 31, an IT consultant in Kolkata, could well be speaking for the entire sorority when she remarks, "I must vote if I want the country to be a better, more equal and just place for women to live in." Vibha Attri, researcher at the Lokniti-Centre for the Studies of Developing Societies (CSDS), in her study of the women vote in India found that they have begun expressing deep faith in the strength of their vote, with 69 per cent believing it makes a difference in how things are run in the country. For women in rural India, says Ireland-based political scientist Vasundhara Sirnate, "the election ID, like the Aadhaar card, has become one more means to access the State." Hence the rush to register as voters. "It has a purpose too—to go and vote."

Their political awareness has come on the back of a whole line-up of factors. Women's participation in local self-government institutions from the 1990s onwards opened an early window for the female cohort on the possibilities contained in the idea of their electoral participation. There is also the self-empowerment thesis, according to which growing literacy, financial empowerment and the rising availability of information raise women's awareness and therefore their participation. Female literacy levels in India have gone up from 26 per cent in 1981 to 69 per cent in 2022, according to World Bank data, even if the distribution is grossly uneven across states and the gender gap remains vast (see *Mixed Blessings*). And while the female labour participation rate (the number of women between 15 and 66 years of age working or seeking work) remains low—37 per cent currently, according to the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) annual report 2022-23—the self-help group revolution has some degree of financial empowerment in pockets across the country. Growing mobile and internet penetration has reached women too, even if in small numbers. According to National Family Health Survey or NFHS-V data, 54 per cent of India's women now have access to a mobile phone, and 33 per cent use the internet.

But literacy alone is insufficient to explain the unleashing of the female political spirit in India, according to Rithika Kumar, a post-doctoral fellow at the University of Notre Dame, US. The lack of literacy, after all, does not affect women's awareness of socio-economic or political issues in India or prevent them from voting, she argues. Instead, she lays greater store by the Election Commission of India's (ECI) efforts to boost the electoral participation of women, particularly its SVEEP or Systematic Voters' Education and Electoral Participation programme since 2009 to increase female turnout and close the gender gap. Women were also provided with a safe environment—including pink booths where election officials as well as security personnel were women—to vote without fear. The results were evident in the 2014 general election, when the number of registered women voters increased by 16 per cent and the gender gap in male and female turnouts narrowed to just 1.5 percentage points. The trend continued in 2019 when the gender gap not only turned in women's favour but the gender elector ratio too improved to 926, the best it had been since 940 in 1989.

And yet, women continue to be underrepresented in electoral rolls, according to Kumar. Even among the registered voters, according to SBI Research estimates, 130 million women voters (147 million if you go by the ECI numbers for 2019) are still untapped. If persuaded to come out and vote, they could significantly alter electoral outcome. Especially since the untapped woman voter base is the highest in Uttar Pradesh (27.5 million), Maharashtra (16.6 million) and Bihar (14.4 million), three states that are crucial to the BJP's tally this election. If more women turn up at the hustings, the saffron party may be able to maintain or better its 2019 tally of 62 seats in UP, even if female loyalties in Bihar and Maharashtra end up divided.

WOMEN IN INDIA HAVE LONG HELD THE FRANCHISE. BUT IT IS ONLY IN THE PAST DECADE THAT THEY HAVE STARTED REALISING THE POWER OF THEIR VOTE

The Voting Emancipation

Women are not just voting but also making up their own mind on who they want to vote for. According to a 2019 women's study by Lokniti-CSDS, though the male influence remained predominant for 33 per cent of the women, 59 per cent were making their own voting decisions. Franziska Roscher, a fellow at New York University, attributes this to the sense of ownership among women in India, with ration cards and houses in their names. And as Sanjay Kumar, professor, CSDS, points out, "Voting on their own, not influenced by the male electorate, gives women a different kind of pleasure, makes them feel better, not a burden on the family." The secret bal-